

CYBERBULLYING

and the queer community

Queer people online are at a greater risk of experiencing online abuse than cisgender people. What are the statistics, what is the issue, and why should we care?

DEFINITIONS

Cyberbullying: the use of technology to bully a person with the intent to hurt or intimidate.

Cyber abuse: behaviour that intentionally uses technology to threaten, harass or humiliate, with intent to harm socially, physiologically or physically.

Cissexism: the belief that being cisgender (a person who identifies with their gender assigned at birth) is natural and superior to other gender identities.

Heterosexism: the belief that the world is heterosexual and all social customs and behaviours should conform.

Unconscious bias: a belief experience by an individual which they are not personally aware of.



TWICE

as many LGBTQIA+ students experience cyberbullying (36.1%) in comparison to their heterosexual counterparts (20.1%).



30%

of LGBTQIA+ adults have experienced online hate speech, in comparison to 14% of the national average.



AT RISK

in 2020, the eSafety Commissioner identified LGBTQIA+ people as an 'at risk' group for increased levels of online abuse. This abuse ranges from scams and dismissive comments, to severe harassment and systemic abuse. The eSafety Commissioner also identified that often low-level micro-aggressions targeted at queer people online often go unreported until they escalate to levels of severe cyber abuse. The lack of recognition of cissexism and heterosexism online places queer people in a more vulnerable position online.

ONLINE SAFETY ACT 2021

establishes a series of notices that are issued to social media providers and end users to remove cyberbullying content, and in some cases restrict users. The Act protects Australian adults and children, however does not specify cissexism or heterosexism as specific issues.



SEX DISCRIMINATION ACT 1984

protects Australian's from being being discriminated against based on their sexual orientations (s5A) or their gender identity (s5B). The Act does not specifically target cyberbullying, however acts as a framework against general discrimination in Australia.



CASE STUDY: *queer people and dating app facilitated sexual violence (DAFSV)*

If queer people are at a higher risk of cyberbullying, how is this violence perpetuated? Are queer people also at greater risk of specific internet violence, such as DAFSV?

DAFSV

DAFSV is sexual **aggression, harassment, and other forms of violence** which occurs through communicating with users on **dating apps**. DAFSV can also include violence which is facilitated through a dating app, which leads to in-person violence being perpetrated.

DAFSV can include:

- image base abuse, including unsolicited sexual photos, pressure to engage in image sharing, and sharing of sexual images to third parties without consent
- abusive or threatening messages
- in-person abuse which has been arranged on a dating app

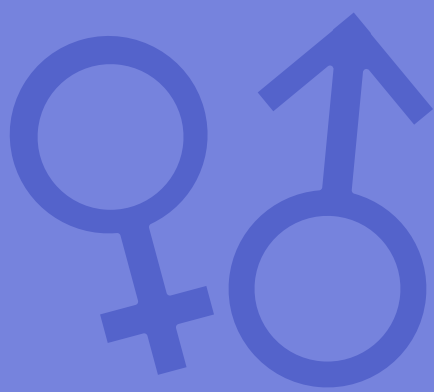
The **most used dating apps** in Australia in 2023 were: Tinder (27%), Bumble (21%), Grindr (8%), Hinge (6%), eHarmony (6%) and Plenty of Fish (2%)

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Australian's have experienced DAFSV in the last 5 years.

83.4%

of female LGBT+, male LGBT+ and non-binary individuals have experienced online DAFSV, in comparison to 70.3% of heterosexual participants.



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accounts of in-person DAFSV were recorded by NSW Police in 2024, with crimes including robbery, assault and extortion.



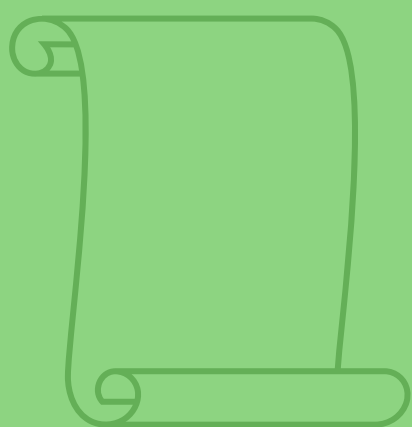
“POSTING AND BOASTING”

Victoria Police's LGBTQIA+ Portfolio Manager Jeremy Oliver, states that many incidents of DAFSV towards queer people involves the filming and posting of the assault on social media. These videos are used in a “shaming process”, threatening to out victims.



COMMUNITY SAFETY

In 2024, Grindr, in conjunction with ACON (queer health group) issued an app wide warning to all NSW users. The warning states that a number of assaults have occurred using Grindr, and gives options to keep users safe when meeting with someone for the first time.



THE CODE

in October 2024, a number of dating sites (including queer site Grindr) in consultation with the Australian Government, formed the Online Dating Code of Conduct. The code requires participating platforms to implement systems to detect DAFSV, take action against perpetrators, and improve and increase complaint and reporting mechanisms. Although the code aims to implement systems of safety for Australian users, it is a voluntary industry made code, hindering Australia's enforceability measures on dating platforms. The code also fails to reflect the disproportionate affect of DAFSV on queer people.

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